
Handout - *Fatema Amijee, “Principle of Sufficient Reason”*

I. The Problem and the Proposed Solution

The Problem:

The *Principle of Sufficient Reason* (PSR) states, roughly, that **everything has an explanation or sufficient reason** (p. 63). Historically central to rationalist metaphysics (Spinoza, Leibniz), the PSR has fallen out of favor because of its allegedly *formidable consequences*:

- **Necessitarianism** (everything is necessary; the world could not have been otherwise)
- The **existence of God** (cosmological arguments)
- The **Identity of Indiscernibles**
- The **Principle of Plenitude**

Contemporary metaphysics, however, has revived interest in **grounding** and **metaphysical explanation**, raising the question:

Can we reformulate the PSR in terms of grounding in a way that preserves its intuitive force while avoiding its traditional excesses?

Amijee's Solution:

Amijee investigates whether a PSR formulated in terms of **ground**—i.e., the claim that *every fact has a ground*—is continuous with early modern rationalism and whether it inherits the problematic consequences. Her strategy is comparative and diagnostic:

1. Clarify grounding and metaphysical explanation (§1).
2. Reinterpret Spinoza's and Leibniz's PSRs through the lens of grounding (§2–3).
3. Reassess the argument from PSR to necessitarianism (§4).
4. Evaluate contemporary defenses of a grounding-based PSR (§5).
5. Explore the rationalist link between explanation and intelligibility (§6).

§1. Grounding and Metaphysical Explanation

Background: The Contemporary Notion of Ground

Grounding is a **metaphysical dependence relation**, often expressed by “in virtue of” or “because.” If [p] grounds [q], then [p] *makes it the case* that [q] (pp. 63–64).

Example:

- A four-dimensionalist claims that an object’s persistence is grounded in facts about temporal stages and appropriate relations between them (p. 63).

Formal Features of Ground (Standard View)

Grounding is typically taken to be:

- **Irreflexive**: Nothing grounds itself.
- **Asymmetric**: If [p] grounds [q], then not vice versa.
- **Transitive**: Grounds of grounds are grounds.
- **Necessitating**: If [p] grounds [q], then necessarily, if [p], then [q] (p. 65).



Note the distinction:

- **Necessitation principle (about grounding) ≠**
- **Necessitarianism (about all facts being necessary).**

This distinction will be crucial in §4.

Metaphysical vs. Causal Explanation

A major interpretive issue:

Is grounding distinct from causation?

- Some treat grounding as **non-causal explanation**.
- Others model grounding on causation.
- Rationalists often formulate PSR in causal terms.

Thus, continuity between rationalist “sufficient reason” and contemporary grounding depends on how tightly causation and metaphysical explanation are connected.

§2. Spinoza: Causation as Ground?

Spinoza formulates PSR in terms of “**cause or reason**” (Ethics Ip11d2) (p. 65). At first glance, this seems causal rather than metaphysical.

Apparent Barriers to a Grounding Interpretation

1. Spinoza speaks of *things*, not *facts*.
2. He uses *causation*.
3. God is *causa sui* (self-caused)—apparently violating irreflexivity.

Amijee's Response

(1) Spinozistic Causation ≠ Contemporary Causation

For Spinoza:

- Causation involves **conceptual connection**.
- Effects are understood *through* their causes.
- Causes necessitate their effects (Ethics Ia3) (p. 66).

This makes Spinozistic causation strikingly close to **grounding**, especially given the necessitation principle.

Key insight:

For Spinoza, to grasp the cause is to grasp what makes the effect intelligible.

(2) Things vs. Facts

Even if PSR applies to “things,” it applies to their existence or nonexistence. On plausible readings (e.g., Della Rocca), unexplained facts entail unexplained states of substance (pp. 66–67). So the scope plausibly extends to facts.

(3) Self-Causation and Irreflexivity

God's existence is explained by God's essence.

This need not violate irreflexivity if:

- Essence ≠ existence.
- Or “one and the same” ≠ strict identity.

Thus, Spinoza's sufficient reason may align with grounding's formal structure more than initially appears.

§3. Leibniz: Conceptual Containment and Truthmakers

Leibniz's PSR:

"No true or existent fact... without there being a sufficient reason why it is thus and not otherwise" (p. 67).

Conceptual Containment Theory

For Leibniz:

- In every true proposition, the **predicate is contained in the subject**.
- A sufficient reason is an **a priori demonstration** reducing the proposition to an identity.

This makes sufficient reason:

- Not primarily causal,
- But a **truthmaking or grounding-like relation**.

Thus, Leibniz's PSR resembles a universal **truthmaker principle**.

God as Ultimate Reason

Leibniz also claims God is the "ultimate reason" for contingent reality (p. 68).

Tension:

- Creation appears **productive**, not constitutive.
- If grounding must be constitutive (Fine), Leibnizian creation may not count.
- If grounding can be productive, it might.

Again, irreflexivity need not be violated: God's existence is explained by divine essence.

§4. The PSR and Necessitarianism

The Bennett–van Inwagen Argument

Let **C** = conjunction of all contingent facts.

1. $PSR \rightarrow C$ has an explanation.
2. If explained by contingent **[p]**, circularity.
3. So **[p]** is necessary.
4. But necessary facts cannot explain contingent ones (given necessitation).

5. So C must be necessary.

→ **Necessitarianism** (pp. 68–69).

Ground-Theoretic Responses

Amijee surveys several strategies:

- Deny coherence of “all contingent truths” (Levey).
- Allow plural grounding (Schnieder & Steinberg).
- Deny that contingent facts can’t be grounded in necessary ones (Pruss; Amijee).
- Reject unrestricted necessitation.

Crucial Point:

Rejecting grounding necessitation is insufficient. One must deny the stronger claim that necessary facts cannot fully ground contingent facts.

Spinoza’s own argument to necessitarianism relies on:

“Whatever follows from something necessary is itself necessary” (p. 69).

Thus, grounding theorists can resist rationalist necessitarianism by rejecting this principle—or restricting it.

§5. Contemporary PSRs

Amijee evaluates several versions:

Dasgupta (2016)

- Grounding chains terminate in **autonomous facts** (often essentialist facts).
- Avoids God.
- But given necessitation, likely still entails necessitarianism (p. 70).
- May trivialize deep questions (e.g., “Why is there something?”).

Della Rocca

- Uses **explicability arguments**: we reject inexplicable states.
- Extends this to all existence facts.
- Ultimately defends radical monism in later work.

Amijee (2017)

- Argues not for PSR's truth but for **commitment to PSR**.
- Participation in *structural inquiry* requires seeking explanation for every fact.
- PSR can be satisfied by infinite explanatory chains (p. 72).

Pruss (2006)

- Restricts PSR to contingent truths.
- Argues infinite regresses are explanatorily circular.
- Defends existence of a necessary being.

Amijee critiques Pruss's regress argument as question-shifting (pp. 71–72).

§6. Explanation and Intelligibility

Here Amijee turns to a deeper issue:

For Spinoza, to conceive is to explain.

Explanation is tied to **intelligibility**.

Grasping the explanans allows a priori deduction of the explanandum.

Contemporary grounding is often weaker:

- It need not guarantee a priori deducibility.
- It need only "illuminate" why the fact obtains.

Example (Amijee forthcoming):

- [It is raining at 3 p.m. July 31, 2019] grounds [It is raining now].
- Not deducible a priori, but explanatory.

Thus, **how tightly we link grounding to intelligibility shapes our metaphysics**:

- Strong link → explanatory demands increase.
 - Weak link → more permissive grounding structures.
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Concluding Themes

1. **Continuity Thesis:**

Spinoza's and Leibniz's sufficient reason is closer to grounding than commonly assumed.

2. **Reformulation Strategy:**

A ground-theoretic PSR can avoid some traditional consequences—but only by revising principles like necessitation.

3. **Explanatory Depth:**

Rationalists tie explanation to intelligibility and conceptual containment.

Contemporary metaphysics often adopts a thinner notion.

4. **Open Structural Question:**

If PSR is true, what does explanatory structure look like?

- God?
 - Autonomous facts?
 - Infinite descent?
 - Radical monism?
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